Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Nahum

Nahum 1:1

- burden ... vision: This opening, like those in other prophetic books (compare Obadiah 1:1; Habakkuk 1:1; Malachi 1:1), identifies Nahum as a prophet who delivered messages from God.
- Nineveh became the capital of the Assyrian Empire shortly after 705 BC and stayed so until its destruction in 612 BC.
- The name Nahum means "comfort" or "encouragement." A key theme of his prophecy is that God will encourage his people through Nineveh's downfall (Nahum 1:12–15; see Isaiah 40:1).

Nahum 1:2

- jealous (or zealous): God jealously protects the well-being of his people and strongly desires their faithfulness (see Exodus 20:4–5; Deuteronomy 4:23–24; 6:4; Jeremiah 2:1–3:5).
- God's vengeance and anger are different from how people seek revenge or try to harm others in return. God's actions come from his:
- holiness (Jeremiah 50:28–29),
- justice (Isaiah 63:1–9), and
- faithfulness to the covenant with his people (Leviticus 26:23–25; Isaiah 1:24–26).

His vengeance is never random or without purpose.

Nahum 1:2–6

The hymn's first stanza uses biblical texts about Israel's exodus from Egypt. It teaches that everything in creation is under God's power. God will punish those who oppose him.

Nahum 1:2–11

This short hymn (a song of praise about God) has two stanzas (1:2–6, 7–11). It speaks about God's supreme power and authority.

Nahum 1:3

- slow to anger: God's patience with disobedience is linked to his faithful love (Exodus 34:6; Numbers 14:18; Psalm 103:8; Joel 2:13). This trait disappointed Jonah, who wanted Nineveh destroyed immediately (Jonah 4:2). Because God is patient, he sometimes delays the deserved punishment of sinners (Nehemiah 9:29–30; Romans 2:4; 2 Peter 3:9), but those who continue to sin will ultimately face God's judgment (Exodus 34:7; Romans 14:10; 2 Corinthians 5:10; Revelation 14:6–7).
- the whirlwind and storm: This imagery describes the fury of God's judgment against the wicked (see also Isaiah 29:6).

Nahum 1:4

- Like clouds (Nahum 1:3) and mountains (1:5), oceans and rivers are under God's control. The Old Testament prophets often recall God's actions against the seas and rivers during the exodus (Exodus 15:8–10; 2 Samuel 22:16; Psalms 66:6; 77:16; Habakkuk 3:15). God's power over the waters challenged the myths of the ancient Canaanites, who believed the sea-god Yam controlled the oceans and rivers.
- Bashan, east of the Sea of Galilee, was known for its rich grasslands, ideal for raising cattle (compare Micah 7:14).
- Carmel, a mountain region on the Mediterranean coast in central Canaan, was well known for its beauty and rich farmland (Song of Solomon 7:5; Jeremiah 50:19).
- Lebanon was famous for its great cedars (1 Kings 5:6–18). Nahum lists these areas to show that even the most fertile and productive places on earth cannot withstand God's judgment.

Nahum 1:5

Poetry in the Old Testament often describes the earth shaking. This language remembers the time of the exodus, when God showed his power as he rescued Israel from Egypt (for example, Psalm 18:7; Habakkuk 3:6; see Exodus 19:18).

Nahum 1:6

The Hebrew word translated "wrath" appears again from Nahum 1:2. This repetition marks Nahum 1:2–6 as one poetic section.

Nahum 1:7

The LORD is good: God judges the wicked fairly. He also offers refuge to those who trust in him. He accepts and protects them during life's challenges (Psalms 18:2; 62:5–7). God's abundant goodness can inspire people to repent (Romans 2:2–4).

Nahum 1:7–11

This second stanza (see study note on Nahum 1:2–11) focuses on God's rule, righteousness, and justice in the way he deals with all people.

Nahum 1:8

overwhelming flood: This is a metaphor for the strong nature of God's judgment (see Nahum 2:6).

Nahum 1:9

Whatever you plot against the LORD: No human plan can succeed against God. Human plans are worthless if they do not align with God's plans (Psalm 2; Isaiah 14:26–27; 23:9).

Nahum 1:11

The counselor of wickedness refers to the Assyrian king. God also addressed the arrogance of an Assyrian king during Hezekiah's time (around 701 BC; see 2 Kings 19:35–36). Assyria's counselor of wickedness contrasts with the coming Messiah, the king who is a "Wonderful Counselor" (Isaiah 9:6).

Nahum 1:12

- The Assyrians' allies were vassal or subordinate kingdoms, including Egypt, which was once powerful. Ironically, a group of former allies gradually brought down the great Neo-Assyrian Empire between 625 and 605 BC.
- God had punished Judah earlier when the Assyrian king Sennacherib, who ruled from 704 to 681 BC, launched a campaign in 701 BC against the western states of the Near East. Although Sennacherib failed to capture Jerusalem (2 Kings 19:32–36), he claimed in his records that he took Jerusalem's tribute and a large amount of spoils from 46 cities in Judah.

Even though Judah had become a vassal state and lived under the constant threat of Assyria, Assyria did not destroy the southern kingdom. Instead, Babylon defeated Judah in 586 BC.
Sadly, neither Israel nor Judah listened to God's many warnings. They did not turn back to him, even though he warned that refusing to repent would bring judgment (Hosea 11:5; Joel 2:1–27).

Nahum 1:14

- no descendants: Nineveh would be completely destroyed. Cutting off a person's name and leaving him without descendants meant total destruction (1 Samuel 24:21; Job 18:17; Isaiah 14:22).
- None of Assyria's respected gods could save Nineveh from God's death sentence.
- God was already preparing a grave for Nineveh and guiding Assyria's enemies to destroy the city. Assyria's proud cities fell one by one to the combined attacks of the Chaldeans, the Medes, and the Ummanmanda. Nineveh itself fell in 612 BC.

Nahum 1:15

Nahum adds to his prophecy about Judah's freedom from bondage (Nahum 1:13) by predicting a messenger will bring news of peace (see also Isaiah 52:7). The peace message was that Assyria's control over Judah would end, freeing God's people from its burden. This happened during King Josiah's reign from 640 to 609 BC, after Assyrian King Ashurbanipal died in 626 BC.

This political message hints at God's final victory over evil. It foretells the release from sin through the Messiah's saving work, granting eternal peace (Zephaniah 3:13; Luke 2:10–14; Acts 10:34–43; Romans 10:15; Ephesians 2:14–18).

Nahum 2:1

Even if Nineveh's defenders prepared with walls, roads, defenses, and forces, they were destined to fail (Nahum 1:1–14).

Nahum 2:2

The vine represents God's blessing to his people (Isaiah 27:2–6), while the stripped vine shows God's earlier punishment of them (Isaiah 5:1–7). The children of Israel were in a sad state compared to the days of the great kings David and Solomon. However, God promised to restore the splendor of his people.

Nahum 2:4

Chariots were almost impossible to stop in battle due to their speed and strength.

Nahum 2:5

- The Assyrian king recovers from the surprise attack on Nineveh and calls out to his officers. He and the city are unprepared, so they hurry to the walls to stop the siege.
- the protective shield is set in place (literally the covering is prepared): The meaning of the Hebrew term here is unclear. Covering probably refers to something that attackers or defenders used for protection. It helped shield them from weapons thrown through the air.

Nahum 2:6

- The rush to defend comes too late (Nahum 2:5). The defenses are already breached.
- Nineveh had a reservoir created by a double dam on the Khosr River, a tributary of the Tigris that flowed through the city. The reservoir was enhanced by a series of flood gates.

The Greek historian Diodorus reported that a great amount of rain had already swollen the city's river system. By first closing, then opening the flood gates, Nineveh's attackers released the stored water as a battering ram against the city walls.

Nahum 2:7

- Because God had decreed Nineveh's exile, it would certainly happen.
- beat upon their breasts: This was a common sign of mourning. People did this to show sorrow and regret (see, for example, Luke 18:13).

Nahum 2:8

The people would flee quickly, like water rushing from a broken reservoir (see study note on Nahum 2:6).

Nahum 2:9

The great wealth from other nations came into the Assyrian capital through trade, tribute, and spoils, but it vanished quickly. Ruthless aggression and wickedness may succeed for a short time, but they will eventually face destruction (Proverbs 13:22; Obadiah 1:15; Luke 12:16–20).

Nahum 2:10

emptied ... desolate ... laid waste: The Hebrew words here use alliteration (repeating similar sounds) to create a strong effect: buqah umbuqah umbullaqah. This sound pattern emphasizes how complete the destruction was. A similar effect in English would be "devastated, despoiled, and destroyed."

Nahum 2:11–13

After describing Nineveh's fall (Nahum 2:1–10), Nahum includes the first of three taunt songs (see also 3:8–13, 14–19). Taunt songs were a common form of poetry in the ancient Near East.

In this song, Nahum uses sharp humor to compare Nineveh to a lion's den. Sennacherib and other Assyrian kings often compared themselves to lions. They even decorated their palaces with images of lions and scenes of royal lion hunts.

However, because God had become Nineveh's enemy, the city would no longer be a safe place for a powerful predator. Its strength and pride would not protect it.

Nahum 2:13

Examples of the voices of Assyria's proud messengers are in 2 Kings 18:19–19:13.

Nahum 3:1

city of blood: The Assyrians' extreme cruelty is well documented. They cut off body parts like noses, ears, hands, and feet. They executed people by impaling them on stakes. They piled severed heads in front of besieged city gates. They sometimes blinded victims and stripped their skin while still alive.

Nahum 3:2–3

- These short, abrupt phrases show how shocking it was to see and hear the battle as it happened.
- Assyrian chariots and charioteers were feared in many lands because of their speed and power.

Nahum 3:4

mistress of sorcery: The Assyrians attracted other nations with wealth and promises of safety and prosperity. However, they then exploited them through military power and economic control. Therefore, their punishment was a fair consequence for their actions (see Proverbs 24:12; Joel 3:4–8; Revelation 18:6; 20:12).

Nahum 3:5

Twice, God tells Nineveh, I am against you (also Nahum 2:13). Nineveh's judgment serves as a historical reminder that the Lord hates sin and will judge people and nations based on their actions (Psalms 9:7–8; 62:12; Jeremiah 46:28; Acts 17:31). One day, God's justice will reach the entire world, affecting those who have rebelled against him (Revelation 17–19).

Nahum 3:8

Thebes was a historic capital of Egypt. The city stood on both sides of the Nile River in Upper Egypt.

Thebes became most famous during Egypt's New Kingdom period, from 1550 to 1069 BC. During this time, it served as the main political, religious, and cultural center of the nation.

By the 600s BC, Thebes was no longer Egypt's capital. Even so, it remained a large and active city.

Nahum 3:9–10

- The Assyrians, led by King Ashurbanipal, conquered Thebes in 663 BC. Before this, Thebes seemed unbeatable with strong defenses and support from Egypt and its allies:
- Ethiopia,
- Put (possibly the legendary land of Punt, located near what is now coastal Somalia), and
- Libya.

However, these allies did not protect Thebes effectively.

- infants were dashed to pieces: In the ancient world, conquering armies sometimes killed the infants of their enemies. This cruel practice was meant to wipe out a people completely and prevent future resistance (2 Kings 8:12; Psalm 137:9; Isaiah 13:16, 18).
- Soldiers cast lots to divide the goods taken in war. At the same time, the leaders of the defeated people were tied with chains and taken away as prisoners (see 2 Kings 25:7; Jeremiah 40:1, 4; Joel 3:3; Obadiah 1:11).

Nahum 3:12

ripe figs: Compare Amos 8:1–2; Revelation 6:13.

Nahum 3:14

Draw ... strengthen: Nahum used sarcasm (sharp words meant to mock) to show that no amount of preparation could protect the Assyrians from God's judgment. He also used this same sarcastic tone in Nahum 2:11–13.

Nahum 3:15

The Old Testament often uses locusts as a metaphor for armies (see Joel 2:1–11).

Nahum 3:16

Assyrian merchants spread across the Near East like locusts, bringing great wealth to Nineveh. However, like locusts that eat and leave, the merchants took their goods and departed during Nineveh's difficult times, leaving the people in need.

Nahum 3:18

- shepherds: With the leaders gone, Nineveh's people would scatter like sheep.
- sleep (see John 11:11–14): Assyria's leaders, asleep during Nineveh's crisis, would sleep in death. In contrast, Israel's Protector does not slumber (Psalm 121:3), and he will gather Israel's lost sheep (Jeremiah 23:3; Ezekiel 36:35).

Nahum 3:19

Nineveh deserved destruction, not healing. Although God showed patience with Nineveh in Jonah's time (Jonah 3:10), the Assyrians returned to cruelty. They would face the consequences of their evil actions (see Proverbs 11:16–19; Isaiah 66:5–6; Hosea 8:7). Those who suffered under Assyria's cruelty would welcome this message with joy.